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Attracting Talented Employees to the Company: Do We Need Different Employer Branding Strategies in Different Cultures?

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Abstract

Attracting and retaining highly talented employees and to consolidate competitive advantage is an important issue for companies in all scales around the world. Understanding what attracts talented recruits to a company may provide important insights for human resources managers. Yet, there is another important question in today's globalised business world: can we use standardized strategies to attract potential employees all around the world, or shall we customize our employer brand according to the cultural differences between the countries. This paper aims to identify perceptual differences concerning the importance levels of different dimensions of employer attractiveness in two different cultures. In doing so, we conducted a quantitative research among 300 university students studying in Latvia and Turkey. Our results suggest that respondents in Turkey attribute a higher importance to attractiveness of employers compared to Latvian respondents. National and cultural difference and gender are also investigated as they offer possibilities for human resources managers to understand theoretical foundations of employer brand and its application in practice.

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1. Introduction

Since competition for highly talented employees became almost as fierce as the competition for customers (Berthon, Ewing and Hah, 2005), companies want to be seen as attractive employers for prospective applicants and current employees (Lievens and Highhouse, 2003). The underlying reason is that human capital brings value to the firm and that organisational performance can be enhanced through skilful investment in human capital (Backhaus and Tikoo, 2004). Within this context, escalated competition for attracting best employees to the firm is named "the war for talent" (Michaels, Handfiels-Jones and Axelrod, 2001). In today's globalised business world, companies in all scales do their utmost to win the war for talent. An important arm in this war is employer branding. In order to attract better employees, firms recently started using branding principles and practices in the area of human resources

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management. The application of branding principles to human resources management has been termed as "employer branding" (Backhaus and Tikoo, 2004).

The concept of employer branding has recently become a prominent topic in the HRM field. Although there is a cornucopia of research on the issue, there still exist some questions to be answered. Are various aspects of "employer branding" or "employer attractiveness" being given equal importance in different cultures? If not, what types of differences do exist? Our paper aims to find answers for such questions. In the process of doing so, this paper identifies dimensions of attractiveness in employer branding and their relative importance in two different countries. We start by presenting the discourse around employer branding, why this is important for the organizations, what are different dimensions that compose the image of an attractive employer in the eyes of current or prospective employees. We aim to track for cross-cultural differences and to identify similarities and contrasts in dimensions of attractiveness in employer branding. In this context, the study begins with a literature review of employer branding and employer attractiveness, then will go on to development of hypotheses. Methodology, analyses and results will take place in the next section. Finally, results of the analyses will be discussed and recommendations will be provided for researchers and academicians in the last section.

2. Literature Review And Hypotheses

2.1. Employer Branding

The term 'employer brand' was first conceptualized by Ambler and Barrow (1996) in their pioneering paper. The concept of employer branding has emerged as a result of the application of the marketing principles to human resource management (i.e. internal marketing). The concept of internal marketing posits that employees are the internal customers of a company and jobs are internal products. To have satisfied customers the organization must first have satisfied employees (George, 1977; 1990). In this sense, employer branding is defined as 'the package of functional, economic and psychological benefits provided by employment, and identified with the employing company' (Ambler and Barrow, 1996, p. 187). According to Sullivan (2004), employer branding is a strategy to manage stakeholders' awareness, perceptions, opinions and beliefs with regards to a particular organization. Employer branding "represents organizations' efforts to communicate to internal and external audiences what makes it both desirable and different as an employer." (Jenner, Taylor, 2007). It is concerned with building an image in the minds of the potential labor market that the company is a 'great place to work' (Ewing et al. 2002).

Several researchers pointed out that organisations with a "good" employer brand will attract more talented applicants (Cable and Graham 2000; Cable and Turban, 2003; Turban and Greening, 1996). Employer branding also helps to retain talented individuals, build trust in leadership and develop stronger bonding ties through its impact on individual, team and organisational engagement (Gittell, Seidner, and Wimbush, 2010). Favorable employer branding can reduce recruitment costs by improving the recruitment performance (Barrow and Mosley, 2005; Berthon, Ewing and Hah, 2005; Knox and Freeman, 2006), contribute to employee retention and reduce staff turnover (Backhaus and Tikoo, 2004; Barrow and Mosley, 2005; Berthon, Ewing and Hah, 2005; Knox and Freeman, 2006) and improve organizational culture (Backhaus and Tikoo, 2004). In order to develop a favorable employer brand, managers have to understand what factors are important in order to attract potential recruits to the firm.

2.2. Organisational Attractiveness

Organisational attractiveness denotes "the envisioned benefits that a potential employee sees in working for a specific organization" (Berthon, Ewing and Hah, 2005, p.156). Jiang and Iles (2011) also see it as "a power" that draws applicants' attention to employer branding and encourages existing employees to stay loyal to a company. Organizational attractiveness is thought of as an antecedent of the more general concept of employer brand equity (Berthon, Ewing and Hah, 2005). Organisational attractiveness is regarded as a multi-dimensional construct. There are various attempts to identify the distinct dimensions of organizational attractiveness (Berthon, Ewing and Hah, 2005; Roy, 2008; Arachchige and Robertson, 2011; Bakanauskien, Bendaravien, Krikštolaitis, and Lydeka, 2011; Sivertzen, Nilsen and Olafsen, 2013) in building employer branding. Berthon et al. (2005) developed and validated a multi-item scale to identify and operationalize the components of employer attractiveness. The authors identified five distinct dimensions of employer attractiveness (such as: interest value, social value, economic value, development value and application value) and provided evidence on the validity and reliability of their scale. They also call for further research to develop and refine the scale. Lievens et al. (2007) used the instrumental–symbolic framework to

study factors relating to both employer image and organisational identity. Kucherov and Zavyalova (2012) divided employer brand attributes into four groups (economic, psychological, functional and organizational) each of them corresponding to different aspects of employer attractiveness.

Examining further attributes of an employer brand is relevant for practitioners and researchers. Organisations need to understand the importance given to each attribute and that these attributes may vary according to cultural difference, demographic characteristics and current employment status of an individual. As we mentioned previously, Berthon et al., (2005) call for further examination of the employer attractiveness scale in different cultures in order to track for cross-cultural differences. Roy (2008) in India, Arachchige and Robertson (2011) in Sri Lanka, and Sivertzen, Nilsen and Olafsen (2013) in Norway responded to this call. These studies revealed that different organisational features and HR practices are valued differently by potential employees. In general, monetary features were found to be less important in terms of attracting and retaining employees compared to non-monetary factors. As another response to Berthon et al., (2005), this study aims to identify similarities and contrasts in the aspects of attractiveness in employer branding in two different samples drawn from Turkey and Latvia.

Turkey is a transcontinental Eurasian country, located mostly on Anatolia in Western Asia, and on East Thrace in Southeastern Europe, with a population of more than 75 Million people (mostly Turks, followed by Kurds and other ethnic groups). Islam is the dominant religion (99%) of Turkey. Turkey is a member of UN, NATO, OECD, European Council and G-20 Major Economies. Turkey began full membership negotiations with the European Union in 2005. Turkey has the world's 15th largest GDP-PPP and 17th largest nominal GDP. Turkish economy was affected by the global financial crisis in 2009, with a recession of 5%. As a result of continuing economic reforms, inflation dropped around 8% in 2005, and the unemployment rate to 10%. On the other hand, Latvia is a country in the Baltic region of Northern Europe with a population of 2.008.700 people (consisting of 62% Latvians, 27% Russians and the rest are other ethnic groups). The largest religion in Latvia is Christianity. Latvia is predominantly Protestant Lutheran, followed by Roman Catholics and Russian Orthodoxes. Latvia is a member of UN, NATO, and EU. For 2013, Latvia is listed 44th on the Human Development Index and as a high income country. Latvian economy was deeply affected by the 2009 global economic crisis; its economy fell 18% in the first three months of 2009, the biggest fall in the European Union. However, by 2010 its economy started to recover. The unemployment rate has receded from its peak of more than 20 percent in 2010 to around 9.3 percent in 2014.

Socio-economic condition of a country (i.e. culture, customs, economic trends or unemployment rates) may influence the level of importance given to various employer attractiveness components. Thus, we propose that *Latvian and Turkish employees attribute different levels of importance to different dimensions of employer attractiveness* (H1). Previous research shows that personal characteristics of potential employees (i.e. gender, age, and educational level) affect the perceived attractiveness of firms as employers (e.g. Albinger and Freeman, 2000; Backhaus, Stone and Heiner, 2002; Newburry, Gardberg, and Belkin, 2006; Froese, Vo and Garrett, 2010). Female and male respondents perceive the relevance of HR practices differently (Albinger and Freeman, 2000; Greening and Turban, 2000; Gould-Williams, 2003; Lievens, Hoye and Schreurs, 2005). Male respondents give a higher importance to compensation than their female counterparts (Batt and Valcour, 2001). Concordantly, we propose that *gender of the respondents may influence the level of importance attributed to different dimensions of employer branding* (H2).

3. Methodology

3.1. Research Goal

Our research objective is to identify dimensions of attractiveness in employer branding. In order to achieve this objective, our study aims to identify what is the perceived importance attributed to each dimension of attractiveness in employer branding and to examine whether there are statistically significant differences in perceptions of Latvian and Turkish respondents. Furthermore, the study aims to examine differences in perceptions amongst male and female respondents.

3.2. Sample and Data Collection

In order to test the research hypotheses, a quantitative approach has been chosen and data was collected using a survey from September 2013 to January 2014. A convenience sample of 300 adults (150 in Latvia and 150 in Turkey)

participated in the study. Nearly half of the respondents (n=120) were employed and the rest (n=130) were unemployed undergraduate and post-graduate university students (University of Latvia, Faculty of Social Sciences and Kocaeli University, Faculty of Economics and Administrative Sciences) at the time of data collection.

Data is collected by a self administered questionnaire which includes demographic questions and the "employer attractiveness" scale developed by Berthon, Ewing and Hah (2005). The "employer attractiveness" scale has 25 items corresponding to the functional, economic and psychological benefits outlined by Ambler and Barrow's (1996) definition of employer branding. Respondents are asked to indicate to what extent they consider the listed items important in choosing an employer? Responses are given on a 5 point Likert type scale where 1= Not at all important and 5= Extremely important. To test the hypotheses, mean scores of responses given to the questions are compared by using independent samples t test.

3.3 Analyses and Results

A total of 300 respondents participated in the study. SPSS software is used to perform data analysis. The mean age of subjects was 21.2 years (range:18-35; sd.=1.99) and 53% were female; 93% were single. Their study fields were mainly the social sciences subjects including business administration, economics, political science, communication, public relations, journalism and international relations. Reliability of the employer attractiveness scale is examined by inter item consistency using Cronbach's Alpha coefficient. Overall reliability of the scale is good ($\alpha = 0,91$)

In general, "Recognition/appreciation from management" (Mean score= 4,13); "An above average basic salary" (Mean score=4,15) and "Having a good relationship with colleagues" (Mean score=4,17) are the most important attributes of an employer to our respondents. On the other hand, "Opportunity to teach others what you have learned" (Mean score=3,33), "Being a customer-orientated organisation" (Mean score=3,42), and "Being a humanitarian organisation – giving back to society" (Mean score=3,47) are the least important attributes of an employer to our respondents.

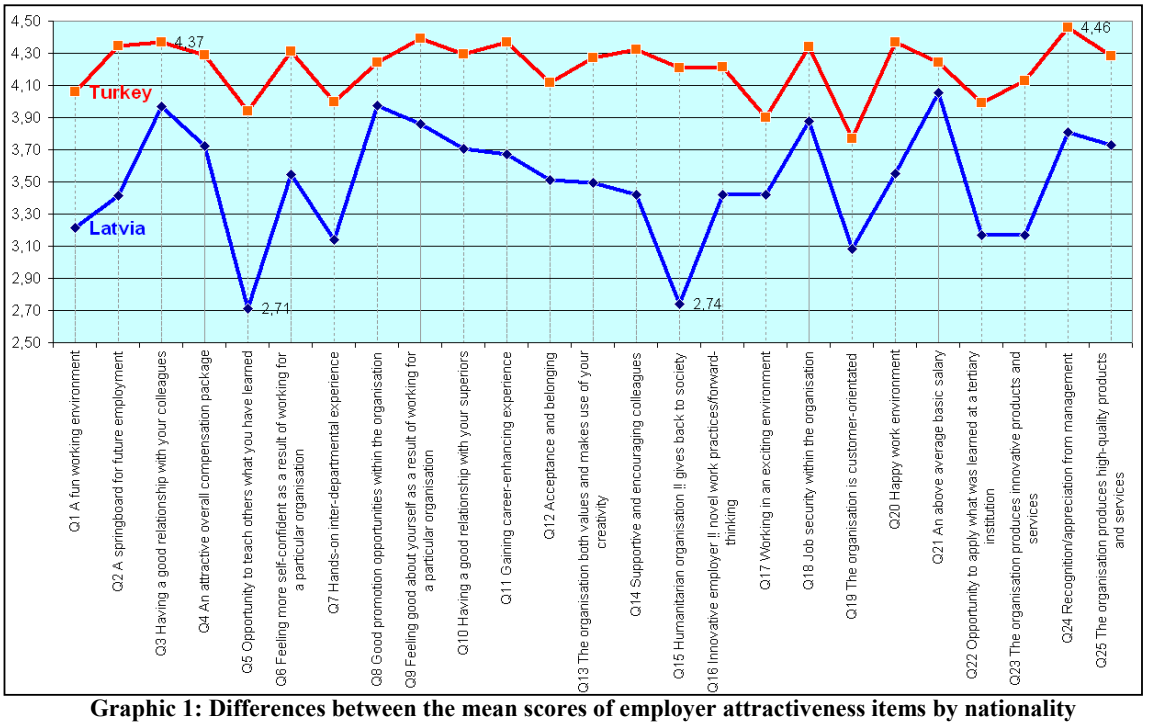
In order to test the first hypothesis, we compared the mean scores of each item by respondents` nationality. Table 1 shows the mean scores and standard deviations of each item and corresponding t-test results. It is found that, except for Q21, (importance given to "an above average basic salary") there are significant differences between the mean scores of the employer attractiveness items regarding the nationality of the respondent. Thus, H1 is supported. In general, Turkish respondents attribute higher importance to all of the employer attractiveness items compared to Latvian respondents. The highest mean differences appear to be on Q15 ("Humanitarian organisation – gives back to society") and Q5 ("Opportunity to teach others what you have learned"). Good promotion opportunities within the organization (Q8) and above average basic salary (Q21) are the items that have the lowest mean differences among Latvian and Turkish respondents.

Table 1. Mean scores and t test results of employer attractiveness items by nationality

	Country	N	Mean	Std. Deviation	Mean Difference	t	Sig (2 tailed)
Q1 A fun working environment	Latvia	150	3,21	1,17	-0,847	-6,41	0,000
	Turkey	149	4,06	1,11			
Q2 A springboard for future employment	Latvia	150	3,41	1,14	-0,933	-7,59	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,35	0,98			
Q3 Having a good relationship with your colleagues	Latvia	149	3,97	0,96	-0,400	-3,66	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,37	0,93			
Q4 An attractive overall compensation package	Latvia	150	3,72	1,07	-0,567	-5,00	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,29	0,88			
Q5 Opportunity to teach others what you have learned	Latvia	150	2,71	1,23	-1,227	-9,49	0,000
	Turkey	150	3,94	0,99			
Q6 Feeling more self-confident as a result of working for a particular organisation	Latvia	150	3,55	1,03	-0,767	-6,91	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,31	0,88			
Q7 Hands-on inter-departmental experience	Latvia	150	3,14	0,94	-0,860	-7,42	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,00	1,06			
Q8 Good promotion opportunities within the organisation	Latvia	150	3,97	0,98	-0,267	-2,47	0,014
	Turkey	150	4,24	0,90			
Q9 Feeling good about yourself as a result of working for a particular organisation	Latvia	149	3,86	1,03	-0,534	-4,63	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,39	0,96			
Q10 Having a good relationship with your superiors	Latvia	150	3,71	0,99	-0,587	-5,50	0,000

	Turkey	150	4,29	0,86			
Q11 Gaining career-enhancing experience	Latvia	150	3,67	0,92	-0,693	-6,56	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,37	0,92			
Q12 Acceptance and belonging	Latvia	150	3,51	1,06	-0,607	-5,37	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,12	0,89			
Q13 The organisation both values and makes use of your creativity	Latvia	150	3,49	0,98	-0,780	-7,08	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,27	0,93			
Q14 Supportive and encouraging colleagues	Latvia	150	3,42	0,99	-0,900	-7,97	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,32	0,96			
Q15 Humanitarian organisation – gives back to society	Latvia	150	2,74	1,10	-1,467	-12,08	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,21	1,00			
Q16 Innovative employer – novel work practices/forward-thinking	Latvia	149	3,42	0,97	-0,791	-7,37	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,21	0,89			
Q17 Working in an exciting environment	Latvia	150	3,42	0,96	-0,480	-4,12	0,000
	Turkey	150	3,90	1,05			
Q18 Job security within the organisation	Latvia	150	3,88	1,00	-0,460	-4,11	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,34	0,93			
Q19 The organisation is customer-orientated	Latvia	150	3,08	1,12	-0,687	-5,41	0,000
	Turkey	150	3,77	1,08			
Q20 Happy work environment	Latvia	150	3,55	1,03	-0,813	-6,98	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,37	0,99			
Q21 An above average basic salary	Latvia	150	4,05	0,98	-0,187	-1,64	0,102
	Turkey	150	4,24	0,99			
Q22 Opportunity to apply what was learned at a tertiary institution	Latvia	150	3,17	0,94	-0,827	-7,31	0,000
	Turkey	150	3,99	1,02			
Q23 The organisation produces innovative products and services	Latvia	150	3,17	1,02	-0,960	-8,59	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,13	0,91			
Q24 Recognition/appreciation from management	Latvia	150	3,81	0,90	-0,653	-6,58	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,46	0,82			
Q25 The organisation produces high-quality products and services	Latvia	150	3,73	0,99	-0,553	-5,25	0,000
	Turkey	150	4,28	0,83			

Graphic 1 shows the differences between the mean scores of employer attractiveness items contrasted by the nationality of the respondents.



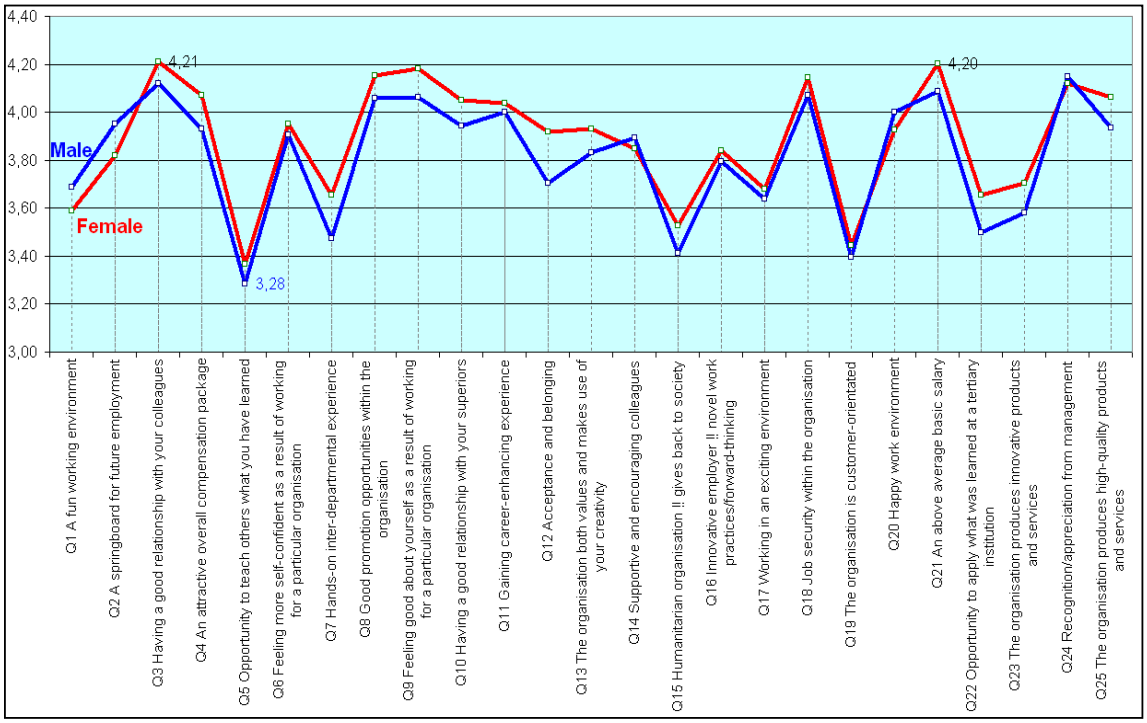
Graphic 1: Differences between the mean scores of employer attractiveness items by nationality

In order to test the second hypothesis, we compared the mean scores of each item by respondents` gender. Table 2 shows the mean scores and standard deviations of each item and corresponding t-test results. It is found that, except for five items (Q1, Q2, Q14, Q20, and Q24) females attributed higher importance to all of the employer attractiveness items. However, there is not any significant difference between the perceived importance levels of employer attractiveness items regarding the gender of the respondents. Besides, level of importance attributed to Q12 ("Acceptance and belonging") is only marginally different between male and female respondents (p=0,068). Thus, we could not find enough evidence to support H2.

Table 2. Mean scores and t test results of employer attractiveness items by gender

	Gender	Mean	Std. Deviation	Mean Difference	t	Sig (2 tailed)
Q1 A fun working environment	Female	3,59	1,22	-0,09934	-0,70	0,482
	Male	3,69	1,22			
Q2 A springboard for future employment	Female	3,82	1,16	-0,13274	-0,99	0,324
	Male	3,95	1,17			
Q3 Having a good relationship with your colleagues	Female	4,21	0,92	0,08829	0,79	0,431
	Male	4,12	1,02			
Q4 An attractive overall compensation package	Female	4,07	0,96	0,1401	1,19	0,236
	Male	3,93	1,08			
Q5 Opportunity to teach others what you have learned	Female	3,36	1,30	0,08109	0,55	0,583
	Male	3,28	1,25			
Q6 Feeling more self-confident as a result of working for a particular organisation	Female	3,95	1,02	0,04188	0,35	0,727
	Male	3,91	1,05			
Q7 Hands-on inter-departmental experience	Female	3,65	1,08	0,17891	1,42	0,156
	Male	3,48	1,10			
Q8 Good promotion opportunities within the organisation	Female	4,15	0,92	0,09421	0,86	0,389
	Male	4,06	0,98			
Q9 Feeling good about yourself as a result of working for a particular organisation	Female	4,18	1,01	0,11971	1,00	0,317
	Male	4,06	1,05			
Q10 Having a good relationship with your superiors	Female	4,05	0,99	0,10705	0,96	0,340
	Male	3,94	0,94			
Q11 Gaining career-enhancing experience	Female	4,04	0,97	0,03774	0,33	0,739
	Male	4,00	0,99			
Q12 Acceptance and belonging	Female	3,92	1,00	0,21611	1,83	0,068
	Male	3,70	1,04			
Q13 The organisation both values and makes use of your creativity	Female	3,93	1,04	0,10103	0,85	0,397
	Male	3,83	1,02			
Q14 Supportive and encouraging colleagues	Female	3,85	1,06	-0,04456	-0,36	0,721
	Male	3,89	1,10			
Q15 Humanitarian organisation – gives back to society	Female	3,53	1,25	0,11695	0,79	0,431
	Male	3,41	1,32			
Q16 Innovative employer – novel work practices/forward-thinking	Female	3,84	1,03	0,04745	0,41	0,685
	Male	3,79	0,99			
Q17 Working in an exciting environment	Female	3,68	1,04	0,04095	0,34	0,733
	Male	3,64	1,04			
Q18 Job security within the organisation	Female	4,14	0,96	0,07373	0,64	0,522
	Male	4,07	1,03			
Q19 The organisation is customer-orientated	Female	3,45	1,22	0,04938	0,37	0,711
	Male	3,40	1,07			
Q20 Happy work environment	Female	3,92	1,11	-0,07547	-0,60	0,549
	Male	4,00	1,06			
Q21 An above average basic salary	Female	4,20	0,93	0,11615	1,02	0,310
	Male	4,09	1,05			
Q22 Opportunity to apply what was learned at a tertiary institution	Female	3,65	1,00	0,15763	1,29	0,200
	Male	3,50	1,13			
Q23 The organisation produces innovative products and services	Female	3,70	1,11	0,12284	0,98	0,326
	Male	3,58	1,05			
Q24 Recognition/appreciation from management	Female	4,12	0,87	-0,02944	-0,28	0,782
	Male	4,15	0,97			
Q25 The organisation produces high-quality products and services	Female	4,06	0,96	0,12672	1,15	0,251
	Male	3,94	0,94			

Graphic 2 shows the differences between the mean scores of employer attractiveness items contrasted by the gender of the respondents.



Graphic 2: Differences between the mean scores of employer attractiveness items by gender

4. Conclusion

This study investigates the possible differences in the perceived levels of importance of different aspects of employer branding (i.e. functional, economic and psychological benefits provided by the employing company) in two different cultures. More specifically, it examines whether there are significant differences in cultures and nationalities on the perceptions of potential employees with regard to the employer brand. The effect of gender as an important individual characteristic is also investigated. Since competition for the best employees became almost as fierce as competition for customers (Berthon, Ewing and Hah, 2005), organizations want to be seen as attractive employers in the employee market (Lievens and Highhouse, 2003). Identifying the perceptual differences in the importance levels of employer branding offers a way for employers to gain a competitive advantage by attracting the "best" employees and retaining them in the company.

Our findings show that Turkish respondents attribute a higher importance to employer attractiveness compared to Latvian respondents in general. Specifically, participants in Turkey perceive aspects of employer branding such as "Humanitarian organisation, gives back to society" and "Opportunity to teach others what you have learned" as being more important when compared to Latvian respondents. On the other hand, "Good promotion opportunities within the organization" and "above average basic salary" are the items that attained similar levels of importance in both cultures. There is not any significant difference between the perceptions of male and female respondents regarding the importance levels of various employer branding aspects.

These findings have some theoretical and practical implications. First of all, human resources professionals should know that distinct aspects of an employer brand are valued differently. In general, "Recognition/appreciation from management" and "Having a good relationship with colleagues" as a social benefit; and "An above average basic

salary" as an economic benefit are the most important attributes of an employer to our respondents. Further, we can say that attractiveness in employer branding is not a universal concept and the perceived importance of employer brand varies in different countries. Human resources specialists should first examine the most valued aspects of the employer brand by their target group and then develop their branding strategies accordingly.

This study has some limitations. First of all, using a convenient sample consisting of undergraduate students may affect external validity and generalizability of research findings. This gives a limited understanding of attractiveness in employer branding seen through the eyes of undergraduate students studying social sciences in Latvia and Turkey. However, it should be noted that university students are the primary source of potential employees in all industries. Organisations often direct their recruitment efforts towards students, since students are likely to apply for a job in near future. Having said that, future studies might cover university students studying different subjects (engineering, medicine, arts, science etc.) as well as employed individuals who have work experience and field expertise in order to gain a wider understanding of the effect of employer branding on employee behavior.

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